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Lone Winner of Ang Serilya

RENZ MARK HIJAPON BAGS 6TH PLACE IN DSPC

Despite the nervousness of being a first timer, Renz Mark T. Hijapon from Kinatarcan National High School's Ang Serilya Publication captured 6th place in Editorial Cartooning- Filipino Category among 200 participants at the 2025 Division Schools Press Conference (DSPC) held on December 1-5, 2025 at Argao, Cebu.

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ANG SERILYA, SSLG HOST DONATION DRIVE FOR EARTHQUAKE VICTIMS

by Josefina M. Almonicar

To provide aid to the earthquake victims that struck Northern Cebu, Ang Serilya (AS), in partnership with Supreme Secondary Learner Government (SSLG), conducted a relief operation for 100 households affected at Sitio Lipata, Purok Kumintang, Bitngil Island on October 5.

The donation drive was initiated by Mrs. Rica Mae P. Villadolid, Ang Serilya Adviser, and encouraged SSLG Adviser Mrs. Donnavil O. Ilustrisimo to take part on the action and was also supported by the faculty and staff of KNHS.

After, a call for donation was posted on the Facebook pages of AS and SSLG which amassed a total of Php 20,177.99 from cash and in-kind donations from teachers, alumni, and locals.

The faculty and staff packed 100 relief packs, each contained rice, canned goods, misua, coffee, biscuits, water, and diapers and candies for kids.

On October 5, School Head Mrs. Katherine R. Escalicas, along with selected faculty and staff, officers of AS and SSLG traveled to Bitngil Island and personally gave the donations.



Hazel Bacolod Arales, a resident in the place, expressed her gratitude to everyone who supported the drive.

"Thank you so much, sir/maam sa grasya nga inyo gipaambit sa Purok Kumintang. God bless ug more blessings sa inyong team sir/maam," she shared.

This initiative reflects the dedication and collaborative spirit of the community, showing that small acts of kindness can make a big difference in the lives of those in need.

Lone Winner of Ang Serilya RENZ MARK HIJAPON BAGS 6TH PLACE IN DSPC

by Joh Lovi Anne D. Osayan



Anchored on the theme, "Voices of Resilience: Equipping Young Journalists to Inspire Preparedness and Positive Change Through AI," the event gathered Cebu Province's promising campus journalists.

Under the guidance of the School Paper Adviser (SPA), Mrs. Rica Mae P. Villadolid and his coach Mr. Daniel P. Villadolid II, the budding cartoonist shone amidst tough competition among student journalists across the province.

Hijapon shared that he felt very nervous as it was his first time joining DSPC, yet he claimed victory with the guidance and mentorship of Mr. Villadolid.

During the contest, he said that he made a mistake where he accidentally put an English label to his supposed Filipino medium.

Because of this, he doubted his chances of winning, but he didn't give up and still believed the process.

At the awarding ceremony, despite his fears and self-doubts, he held on to his prayers and unexpectedly won.

"Kulba siya kay first time and wa baya ko nag-expect na makaplace ko kay damo ko'y sipyat. Akon category is Filipino but English akon naswat. So, sa time pag awarding daw awo kaayu wa ko'y nawong ikapakita sa mga teachers specially kay Sir Daniel kay amo lagi to damo'y error but gihatag sa Ginoo akon pag-ampo wa gyud ko Niya gipasagdan gipaplace gyapon ko bisan damo'y error, so thankful kaayu ko kay naka experience ko sadtu and nakadto ko'y Argao," he shared.

With this, his accomplishment brought honor and pride to Kinatarcan National High School and Ang Serilya Publication, lighting the way for future journalists.



KNHS shifts to blended learning post-earthquake

by Mae Gilbuena

After more than a month of class suspension due to the earthquake, Mayor Ithamar P. Espinosa announced on his Facebook page the resumption of face-to-face classes on November 17.

With this, Kinatarcan National High School (KNHS) enforced a blended learning modality across all grade levels as the school cannot accommodate all students due to minor structural damage of several classrooms.

While no injuries were reported, school officials deemed it necessary to implement a temporary schedule to prioritize safety and allow for comprehensive inspection of all damaged classrooms and will remain in effect until these assessments are completed and necessary repairs have been made.

Moreover, for junior high school learners, the morning shift is scheduled face-to-face every Monday-Tuesday, from 8:00-5:00 PM while on Alternative Delivery Mode every Wednesday-Thursday. For the afternoon shift, the students will be on Alternative Delivery Mode every Monday-Tuesday, whereas face-to-face classes on Wednesday-Thursday, still from 8:00-5:00 PM.

Meanwhile, for senior high school students, Grade 11 will follow the same schedule of JHS morning shift and Grade 12 will emulate the schedule of JHS afternoon shift.

Furthermore, every Friday is allotted for the submission of all modules and to be passed personally by the parents of the learners.

School Head Mrs. Katherine R. Escalicas emphasized the importance of prioritizing safety during this period while still providing quality education to the student even in the face of adversity.

The school community is working together to overcome the challenges posed by the earthquake and ensure a safe and productive learning environment for all.



KNHS implements multi-sectoral strategy to curb teenage pregnancy

by Journey Batiancila Jr.

Kinatarcan National High School (KNHS) has launched a comprehensive initiative to address the rising challenge of teenage pregnancy among its students for the school year 2025-2026.

Current school data reveals six recorded cases of pregnancy: three in Grade 10, two in Grade 11, and one in Grade 12.

To ensure these students can continue their education without delay, KNHS—with support from the DepEd Santa Fe District—has integrated Inclusive Education through Alternative Delivery Modes (ADM).

This system provides students with tablets and modular or online learning tools, allowing them to balance their studies with the demands of early parenthood.

One anonymous student shared the reality of this struggle, noting, “It is difficult to manage a pregnancy while studying. You are constantly torn between your academic priorities and the urgent needs of your child, especially when they fall ill.”

Beyond academic support, the school is focusing on prevention.

Mrs. Katherine Escalicas led an orientation aimed at educating students on the long-term consequences of early pregnancy.

The program also included age-appropriate information on reproductive health tools, such as condoms and contraceptive pills to help adolescents make informed decisions not to promote sex but to develop and open their minds.

The community has also taken a proactive stance about such issue.

Faculty members and staff have collaborated with barangay officials and local stakeholders to suggest a 9:00 PM to 5:00 AM curfew for minors that aims to establish proper conduct of safety and security.

“Education and monitoring are not the sole responsibility of teachers,” Mrs. Jenelyn Canales, School Guidance Designate emphasized in our interview.

“Parents must play a primary role in supervising their children’s activities and peer groups, especially during the evening,” she added.

KNHS remains committed to providing ongoing reproductive health education and strengthening community partnerships to ensure a brighter future for the youth of Kinatarcan Island especially among adolescents.

Wiping Out Reading Dilemma

KNHS LAUNCHES ARAL PROGRAM

by Frijun M. Hijapon

In accordance with Republic Act No. 12028, Kinatarcan National High School (KNHS) officially implemented the Academic Recovery and Accessible Learning (ARAL) Program to ease reading illiteracy among junior high school learners, last Tuesday, February 3.

This is to address learning gaps and recover learning losses. It focuses initially on Reading, Mathematics, and Science to ensure students reach grade-level competencies, with promising initial results in improving reading skills.

In essence, ARAL aims to turn learning setbacks into opportunities, fostering student success through focused academic recovery efforts.

There are 35 students from KNHS who are required to take part in the program: seven in Grade 7; five in Grade 8; three in Grade 9; and 20 in Grade 10.

Tutoring will be conducted by Mr. Joemer Alolor for Grades 7 and 9, Ms. Milka Ungui for Grade 8, and Ms. Anna Mae Mata for Grade 10.

Moreover, the ARAL Program requires two hours each day for two days a week, totaling four hours every week and will last for eight weeks.

Consequently, the lesson will take place only during students’

students’ vacant class schedules and will not pull them out during class hours.

“For example, ila klase kay Martes, dili kami mo-pull-out during klare. Adto namon sila i-one-on-one or i-tutor daring sa day nga wala silay klase like Miyerkules or Huwebes where bakante sila,” he reiterated.

According to Mr. Joemer Alolor, ARAL Program Coordinator, an orientation was held for the parents of the learners, but only three attended.

“Ara’y program orientation specially sa mga mama nga may anak nga dili kantigo ug tabangonon sa pagbasa para makahibawo ang mga ginikanan sa pamaagi sang ARAL Program,” Sir Alolor stated.

However, if no improvements are observed within those eight weeks, the program will continue over the summer after teachers’ 30-day vacation.





SSLG, BKB launch outreach program for elderly, sick

by Ashley Jhen Valle

The Supreme Secondary Learner Government (SSLG) and Barkada Kontra Bisyo (BKB) of Kinatarcan National High School conducted a house-to-house outreach activity to aid the elderly and sick at Barangay Hagdan and Kalusayan last Friday, December 19, 2025.

Anchored on the theme, “Spirit of Christmas: Sharing Love and Compassion,” the activity aimed to show the true meaning of Christmas by sharing kindness and care with those in need.

Most of the beneficiaries were elderly individuals, including one person who is currently battling breast cancer.

The program started with a prayer before the distribution

of goods. The officers gave rice, noodles, coffee, canned goods, and biscuits to ten selected households.

Before handing out the donations, the officers first sang Christmas carols to the beneficiaries to bring joy and warmth to their homes.

Instead of receiving Christmas gifts as carolers usually do, they chose to do the opposite by giving gifts and sharing blessings.

Overall, the outreach program was successful and meaningful, showing unity, compassion, and the true spirit of Christmas through acts of kindness and generosity.

KNHS conducts SMEA

by Frijun M. Hijapon

Kinatarcan National High School (KNHS) held its School Monitoring, Evaluation and Adjustment (SMEA) for the Second Quarter, S.Y. 2025-2026, with the theme, “Sustaining Excellence through Results-Based Accountability and Shared Governance.”

The said event was attended by the Faculty and Staffs of KNHS, Barangay Captains and Barangay Officials of Kinatarcan, Langub, and Hagdan, the SSLG officers and BKD officers as well and was hosted by Ms. Leonaly Plenos.

The program started by showing patriotism and nationalism through the singing of the Philippine National Anthem. It was followed by a solemn prayer, and the singing of Sugbo Hymn and the KHNS Hymn.

Afterwhich, a Presentation of Participants was done by the School Guidance Designate, Ms. Jenelyn P. Canales. To set the mood of the attendees, an energizer was conducted by Ms. Jessa Jumawan and Ms. Elizabeth Ribo.

Faculty President Miraflor Bueno shared the objectives of the event: Monitoring MEA activities each quarter to ensure effective program execution, Addressing Challenges to identify and address issues encountered during activities to improve school program outcomes, Providing Technical Assistance and recommends strategies to enhance data for decision-making, and Aligning with Education Frameworks that align with DepEd’s BEMEF and support the Basic Education Plan 2030.

Following this, the SMEA proper started

with the Presentation of the 2nd Quarter SMEA Performance Indicators by Mrs. Katherine R. Escalicas, School Head of KNHS.

In her part, she shared the following Performance Indicators: a. Access; b. Quality; c. Governance, and d. Resiliency and Well-Being in enhancing educational outcomes through continuous assessment. In addition, she shared the School Profile (Access) and the number of Faculty and Staffs of KNHS, along with the number of students each grade level.

She also added the summary of best school practices including ISLA BASA and SULBAD, Mano Po Culture, Basura Ko, Ibulsa Ko, and among others, as well as the school’s accomplishment.

In line of this, she also lamented some of the pressing issues the school is facing right now and is hoping to be solved: the water supply

system, rewiring the entire school electrical system full establishment of TVL laboratory, proper disposal of garbage, and the pathway of concreting of school entrance.

In return, a message of response was given by the SPTA President Belinda Placencia. It was continued by Hon. Vilma Dawa, Barangay Captain of Hagdan, Hon. Raul Batirzal responded on behalf of Hon. Tito Mondejar, Barangay Captain of Langub, Lastly, Hon. Marcos Gilbuena, Barangay Captain of Kinatarcan, uttered positive news and is willing to extend the best of his ability to help KNHS in any way possible.

Afterwhich, awarding of certificates and photo opportunity was done, to give appreciation and commend everyone for the efforts exerted.

The program ended with a prayer by Faculty Member Mr. Renante Olarte. Finally, the guests were served with refreshments.



COMMUNITY NEWS

Boat fare rises amid strict passenger limits

by Frijun M. Hijapon



Pursuant to Republic Act No. 9295, also known as the “Domestic Shipping Development of 2004,” boat operators must strictly enforce passenger loading limits based on each vessel’s approved capacity by Maritime Industry Authority (MARINA) starting on January 12.

This initiative was enforced by the coast guards after eyeing the potential risks and accidents when overcrowded passengers occurred after New Year’s Day.

Based on the approval of MARINA, the maximum passengers in each boat are 20 pax for Rosedarlene; 34 pax for Rosedarlene 2; 24 pax for Argem, Clarence, and Darvel; 28 pax for Sto. Niño, Kenzo, and Rica Love; 22 pax for HD; and 18 pax for JR, with no excess passengers allowed and wearing life vest is a must.

Moreover, ASN Marlon G. Leonoras, one of the coast guards in Kinatarcan, emphasized the existing mandatory guideline as they cannot easily afford to have congestive passengers on-board.

“Ang mga bangka may mga capacity man yun, hindi tayo pwedeng basta-basta magkarga nalang ng mga pasahero kasi baka mag-overload yung bangka eh malunod,” Leonaras stated.

In prompt with this, boat owners have raised fares to offset lost revenue from reduced loads and maintain profitability.

For passengers going to Daanbantayan, regular fares jumped from ₱100 to ₱D150, while seniors and students now pay ₱100, up from ₱50. Meanwhile, for Santa Fe, the fare increased from ₱120 to ₱200.

As a result, the hikes have drawn disapproval among island residents and crews but later understood the weight of everyone’s safety.

In a sought interview with Lyn Jumola, a resident in Kinatarcan, shared she is greatly affected, but she is also aware that boat owners are much more affected.

“Apektado kami pero mas ang boat owners kay minimum naman lang sara ila karga”, she highlighted.

Marjun Almonicar, a boat crew, also nods at this indication pinpointing the old method is better and more profitable but got swayed by the coast guards’ point on this matter.

“Dili man kami uyon sa capacity pero nituman nalang kami sa coast guard kay safety man ang giuna”, he stated.

However, challenges persist on return trips to the island, which is beyond Kinatarcan Island coast guards’ control resulting to lax enforcement of the guideline—making passengers overcrowded and boats overloaded, yet transportation fee remains to maximize boat owners’ income.

LGU-Kinatarcan raises concern over minors driving

by Josefina M. Almonicar

The local officials of barangay Kinatarcan has reiterated its strict enforcement of “no license, no driving policy” on the rising concerns of students and minors under 18 who are driving without a valid license.

In an interview with Barangay Captain Marcos Gilbuena, he shared that multiple motorcycle accidents have been reported across the island, and this year alone, there have been numerous reports of minors driving motorcycles unsafely.

He echoed that authorities are strictly enforcing the law, and the police will monitor violations.

Once caught, parents will be called immediately. After three warnings, fines range from ₱3,000 to ₱10,000. More serious violations can result in jail time—up to six years and a day for those convicted.

“These rules aren’t to scare anyone. They exist to protect lives,” he emphasized.

Moreover, another pressing issue is the noisy motorcycles, particularly in Barangay Hagdan, which have caused widespread complaints among residents. These motorcycles not only disturb the community but also pose safety risks.

He expressed that safety is a shared responsibility, and with proper enforcement and education, accidents and violations can be reduced.

“It’s everyone’s job—officials, parents, and the community—to make sure our young riders stay safe. Let’s work together to prevent accidents before they happen,” he concluded.

To educate the community and reinforce responsible driving, a road safety seminar is scheduled on February 27 among barangay captains, officials, tanods, and school personnels to discuss traffic rules, importance of helmets, proper licenses, and ways to guide the community in preventing accidents.

KINATARCAN STANDS STRONG

Withstand Earthquake, Typhoon with No Major Damage

by Joh Lovi Anne D. Osayan

Kinatarcan endured back-to-back natural disasters—a magnitude 6.9 earthquake on September 30, 2025, and Typhoon Tino about a month later—emerging unscathed, with no major damage reported which served as stark reminders of the importance of disaster readiness, prompting calls for more drills and vigilance.

The earthquake struck at 9:59 p.m., shaking the island with Intensity VII-VIII forces. Thousands of aftershocks followed, driving terrified residents to sleep outside amid constant rain from the approaching typhoon.

Rosanna Montolo, a mother of five in the barangay, shared her experience.

“Earthquakes come without warning. Thank God we weren’t asleep yet, but during the earthquake we panicked and forgot to follow safety protocols like duck, cover, and hold. Aftershocks kept us scared so we slept outside amid constant rain from the coming typhoon but thank God no one was hurt from that tragedy. I hope it won’t happen again, that kind of incident,” she recalled.

A month later, on November 4-5, Typhoon Tino battered the area with heavy rain and winds under Signal No. 2. Residents sprang into action: Fishermen hauled boats to higher ground to evade big waves, secured food supplies, and tied down roofs to prevent them from flying off. Evacuations happened swiftly.

Fisherman Roberto Francisco recounted, “When we heard news of the typhoon, we got ready right away—we secured the fishing gear, prepared, and the captain said we needed to evacuate, so we evacuated immediately for our own safety.”

Barangay Captain Honorable Marcos Gilbuena credited community preparedness for the zero-damage outcome.

“The earthquake can’t be forecasted, so we need to stay alert,” he said in an interview. “That event is an eye-opener for us to discipline ourselves in regularly conducting INSET, the national synchronized earthquake drills. We must have knowledge to help us if another disaster comes. On Bagyong Tino, always be ready—those near the coast must evacuate for sure. Luckily, we’re quite distant from the typhoon. Thanks to God, there was no damage, or anyone harmed during this phenomenon.”

Today, Barangay Kinatarcan stands resilient. Regular drills and strong community unity have fortified the area, ensuring better preparedness for whatever nature may bring next.

LGU-Langub laments over double parking, plans parking space reallocation

by Frijun M. Hijapon

The Local Government Unit (LGU) of Barangay Langub held a meeting to address the parking crisis in Pasil at the Langub Covered Court at 3:05 p.m. on February 20.

The meeting, led by Barangay Captain Hon. Tito “Boy” Mondejar, was attended by boat owners, motorbike riders, barangay officials, purok leaders from Pasil, and coast guard personnel.

Its main objective was to tackle the parking shortage at Pasil port, where motorcycles often overcrowd the area, narrowing the road and risking injuries.

Attendees shared numerous recommendations to resolve the motorcycle congestion.

One government official warned that if the issue persists, “boat owners will be penalized by relocating to Dapdap as their new port.”

The vice president of the habal-habal drivers’ group proposed one-sided parking, with all motorcycles aligned along the right side of the road.

Meanwhile, a purok president suggested designating a specific parking lot for motorcycle riders.

After hearing all suggestions, Captain Mondejar outlined a strategy to resolve the ongoing issue.

Ultimately, participants agreed to prohibit all motorcycle parking within Pasil port. Instead, motorcycles from Barangay Kinatarcan and Langub must park at Pasil’s waiting shed, while those from Dapdap and Hagdan must use Pasil’s Wellness Resort.

This new protocol will be implemented as soon as possible to alleviate the hardships.



Ang Serilya

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DISMANTLE CORRUPTION For a Better Nation

When President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. signed the 2026 national budget of 6.793 trillion pesos, a wave of skepticism swept through the nation. Dubbed the “people’s budget,” it promises aid for education, health, and infrastructure. Yet many Filipinos wonder: Will these funds truly reach the people, or will they vanish into politicians’ pockets once more?

The recurring scandals—substandard bridges collapsing, ghost projects draining billions—have left citizens weary and grieving. Recent disasters tied to shoddy infrastructure have claimed lives, inflicted trauma, and stalled the futures of millions.

As transparency erodes, one urgent question demands an answer: What can ordinary Filipinos do to combat corruption in a system that seems rotten at its core?

Various reports show how public funds intended for social services, infrastructure, and community development are sometimes delayed, reduced, or lost due to corrupt practices. Transparency watchdogs and audit findings often reveal irregularities in government spending. In fact, the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP) identified 252 non-existent or ghost projects across the country. These fake projects are clear evidence of corruption, showing how public funds meant for development are stolen or misused.

Corruption weakens democracy and erodes public trust. When citizens lose confidence in their leaders and institutions, participation decreases, and accountability suffers. If we want a peaceful country, we must confront corruption not only as a political issue but as a moral crisis.

The 1987 Constitution, under Article III, Section 4, guarantees citizens the right to speak freely, express opinions, and peacefully assemble or petition the government. These rights empower people to question leaders, expose wrongdoing, and demand transparency and accountability. By using our voices responsibly and courageously, we can help prevent corruption and protect democracy.

According to the Pulse Asia 2025 survey, 94% of Filipinos believe corruption is widespread in the government. It’s encouraging that so many are aware and concerned, but alarming that the perception is so high, reflecting how deeply it has affected our government and society.

Moreover, Transparency International’s Corruption Perceptions Index ranked the Philippines 120th out of 182 countries. This poor standing underscores how our people continue to struggle with substandard and ghost projects that cost lives.

It’s time to wake up from this long, deep sleep! Let us open our eyes to see that government officials’ actions are often mere shows to impress, keeping us in a loop while they blatantly misuse and plunder the people’s funds.

We, Filipinos have in common—no exemption, all struck by poor governance. We all break our bones each day, shedding sweat under the sun, and back stiffens for a long hour of work. Yet, all the hard work, the determination for a cozy life, and the hope for a better tomorrow is just



a mere faith as crocodiles chumped every ounce of goods meant for the people—depriving what’s ours.

Some argue that fighting corruption is solely the responsibility of government agencies and that ordinary citizens have limited power. However, history proves otherwise: Reforms gain momentum only when citizens demand them. Consider the EDSA People Power Revolution—a bloodless uprising that restored democracy in the Philippines. This shows that without public pressure, investigations lose urgency. Citizen engagement doesn’t replace institutions; it strengthens them.

Fighting corruption is like protecting a house from termites. Government agencies may act as pest control, but homeowners—the citizens—must regularly inspect, report damage, and maintain the structure. If owners ignore warning signs, the infestation spreads. Likewise, when citizens remain silent, corruption grows unnoticed.

Earthquakes and floods cannot bring the country down—but greed can. Senator Robin Padilla is wrong to call this generation’s youth “weak.” It’s not just the youth; all Filipinos have grown weak by choosing corrupt leaders. Why have we allowed ourselves to be blinded for so long?

Wake up, people! It is time to stand up for justice. To prevent corruption, Filipinos need to take responsibility: reject vote-buying, refuse to accept or give bribes, stay informed, and critically evaluate leaders before voting—choosing those with proven records of honesty and competence. Corruption won’t stop overnight due to entrenched systems, but these steps can minimize it.

Filipinos, the power to end this cycle lies in our hands. Rise like we did in EDSA—united, fearless, and unrelenting. Demand audits, vote wisely, and hold every official accountable. Our children deserve a corruption-free Philippines: prosperous, transparent, and truly for the people.

The time for excuses is over. Act now or lose our nation forever.



The Rise of Cost for Safety Over Survival

by Frijun M. Hijapon, Micah Alliana C. Baterzal, Syka Ilustrisimo

The ticking alarm woke me at 3:00 a.m. in the dim dawn. I got up to prepare the portable things I'd bring on my journey to Daanbantayan. To get there, I rode a motorcycle as early as the rooster's cock-a-doodle-do, only to find an endless line of passengers. In the far distance, I saw coast guards roaming the area, ensuring that all boats carried only their maximum registered capacity per the Maritime Industry Authority (MARINA). After we arrived at Daanbantayan port, I eavesdropped on a fellow student murmuring, "Ka mahal lagi?" Then the boat operator said, "Dyutay da ang karga para makabawi kami." However, boats returning to Kinatarkan have no passenger limits, yet charge the same fare with different restrictions.

This isn't a fictional story but a growing social dilemma for Kinatarcans. Boat owners suddenly raised transportation fees after coast guards strictly enforced the rule that "the maximum capacity of boats is based on registered on-board passengers in MARINA, not estimated boat capabilities." Commuting from Kinatarkan prioritizes safety: passengers are limited aboard boats and must wear life jackets securely. Yet traveling back to the island has no limits, no life jackets, and overcrowded passengers, but still charges a static fare.

It all began on the first day of 2026, when tourists, relatives, and Kinatarkan residents simultaneously left the island for work, school, or their respective homes. All departing boats were full; plenty of people struggled to board, and many were left behind. To on-duty coast guards, the scene was unacceptable. The ratio of boats to people was unlikely to be 1:80, and with no life jackets, potential risks were likely to rise. Coast guards later concluded: strictly enforce maximum capacity per boat. This is backed by Republic Act No. 9295, the "Domestic Shipping Development Act of 2004," the primary legislation governing boat safety, registration, and regulation in the Philippines. Boat owners were oriented from January 26 to February 1 for this sudden implementation—whether they liked it or not. So, a sharp rise in fares became the repercussion, allowing boat owners to avoid deficits. This shows that the Coast Guard prioritizes people's safety, and for boat owners to deal with this predicament, raising fares is a must.

However, interviews reveal that boats have no restrictions when traveling back to Kinatarkan. Enforcement is equivalent in talk but inconsistent in practice: strict within the island for safety, loose when returning to Kinatarkan. The key lies with the

coast guards on duty. According to Marjun Almonicar, a crew member of the Rose Darlene boat, it stems from differing enforcement styles—in Daanbantayan it's approved, while here it's strictly prohibited. Same duties and responsibilities, but different approaches: one plays it safe, the other is more considerate. This breeds disapproval from Kinatarcans, though they also understand the island coast guards' point. In fact, Mrs. Lyn Jumola, a Kinatarkan resident, stated that people want the old way—where they can save—and amore profitable setup for boat owners, but she also grasps the coast guards' intention. This highlights that while Kinatarcans want to save money, they understand the crucial role of safety and dedicated enforcers.

Some object and suggest implementing the rule only when the weather is bad; otherwise, safety isn't threatened because boats' capabilities exceed MARINA's maximum. They say adding capacity to registration costs a fortune, so their proposal is simple: less rigidity on tranquil days.

Some people think we should only limit passengers when the weather is bad. This doesn't make sense. Things can go wrong on a boat even when the sun is shining. A boat can break down. Someone can make a mistake. The sea can get rough fast. That's why we have rules to keep people safe. If we don't follow them all the time, it's not fair—some get special treatment, and that's not right. Without consistent enforcement, people lose trust in those meant to protect them. Safety is important. We should always follow the rules, no matter what.

Imagine your child boarding a crowded boat without a life jacket. One big wave or mishap could be disastrous. For Kinatarcans, the sea is central to life. It connects people to schools, markets, hospitals, and opportunes beyond the island. Every boat ride isn't just travel—it's about returning to family. If paying more ensures safety, it's worth it. Losing a loved one hurts far worse than higher fares. Safety rules may feel like a hassle, but they're there to get everyone home safely.

Kinatarcans face a tough balance: safety versus affordability. Enforcing rules consistently saves lives. Inconsistent application breeds confusion and resentment. Now more than ever, cooperation is needed among local leaders, boat operators, and the community. We need fair, uniform rules and dialogue to find ways to protect lives while sustaining livelihoods. Transportation should unite communities, not create barriers. We shouldn't choose between safety and survival—we can have both. That's the goal for Kinatarcans and their boats.

When The Mask Begins To Crack

by Micah Alliana C. Baterzal

"Bagong Pilipinas, Bagong Mukha."

The slogan rolls off the tongue—catchy, optimistic, a promise of renewal. It dominated campaign stages and social media feeds in 2022. But four years into President Ferdinand "Bongbong" Marcos Jr.'s term, as rice prices soar past ₱60 per kilo (up 20% from 2024 levels, per the Philippine Statistics Authority) and families scrape by, it's fair to ask: Is this "new face" more than empty rhetoric?

It is no secret that 2025 and 2026 have seen a slew of issues associated with the administration of President Ferdinand Marcos Jr., known as Bong Bong Marcos. From eroded trust due to the use of confidential and intelligence funds to reports of economic hardship, protests filling the streets, and unresolved tensions in the West Philippine Sea, these issues awaken the public—especially college students and families struggling day-to-day—to question the adequacy of his leadership.

These issues are not mere numbers in surveys—they resonate with me as a Filipino.

As a young woman living on an island with my family, I well understand the necessity for strict budgeting, careful shopping, and the constant worry that my money might not last through the week due to the rising costs of everyday items. In the face of daily struggles, I feel the weight of a nation with unclear governance and the harsh realities that seem unavoidable.

There are undeniable facets to consider.

While there are projects and reforms, gaps in implementation, transparency, and real impact on ordinary citizens persist in Bong-Bong Marcos's administration.

Many people are voicing their grievances about his governance—I feel the lack of action regarding food prices and public services. Words alone are insufficient—the consequences serve as the real evidence.

Despite several agricultural initiatives, farmers continue to face high costs for fertilizers and other essentials, and a considerable amount of smuggled products floods the market. As a result, local farmers do not benefit, and prices in local markets rise—a direct hit on the daily lives of Filipinos, particularly for families like mine living on an island.

He himself has taken charge of the Department of Agriculture but has overseen no meaningful changes.

The issue of confidential and intelligence funds also raises eyebrows. Numerous reports question where the money goes, contributing to declining public trust in the government. Transparency regarding these funds is crucial, as they constitute taxpayer money, and a lack of clear reporting fosters a perception of insufficient accountability.

Another undeniable issue is the decline of the Philippines in the Corruption Perceptions Index by Transparency International. In the 2025 CPI, the country dropped to 120th place globally, below average, with a score of just 32 out of 100—indicating a high level of "perceived corruption" in public sectors. Reports even suggest that the Philippines is sometimes ranked as the third highest in corruption perceptions in Southeast Asia.

Public protests and political fallout are clear signals of the people's discontent. These rallies and protests are not merely emotional outbursts—they represent the frustrations of the masses.

The administration has taken steps, claiming to aim for reform and transparency, such as prioritizing budgets for human capital and economic recovery plans and launching monitoring systems for infrastructure spending.

"Bagong Pilipinas, Bagong Mukha" is devoid of significance for I have never witnessed any change, as the unpleasant systems in the Philippines persist to this day—there remains an absence of transformation for Filipinos.

I hope that in the next generation, Filipinos will vote wisely, and they will indeed vote wisely.

For the face of the Philippines has not changed at all.

One Click, One Share: The Erosion of Our Values

by Precious Venus D. Buan

In the Philippines, where social media consumption exceeds 80 million users, viral scandals have become daily spectacles. Just last month, a leaked intimate video of "Gold Medalist" exploded across TikTok and Facebook, racking up millions of views in hours. Thrill-seekers didn't hesitate: they shared, commented with vicious judgments, and turned private pain into public entertainment. This isn't isolated—cases of non-consensual intimate video sharing, often dubbed "revenge porn," surge yearly, with the Philippine National Police reporting over 1,000 cybercrime complaints in 2025 alone related to online sexual exploitation. Platforms like Instagram Reels and X (formerly Twitter) amplify these breaches at lightning speed, stripping victims of privacy and dignity while fueling a culture of voyeurism. What starts as a "one click, one share" spirals into widespread mental trauma, especially for young people still shaping their values.

This reckless behavior doesn't just invade privacy; it inflicts deep harm. Victims endure cyberbullying, anxiety, depression, and even suicidal thoughts, as documented by mental health groups like the Natasha Goulbourn Foundation. For students and minors—who make up a huge chunk of social media users—the fallout is devastating. Research from the Pew Research Center and local studies by the University of the Philippines reveals that about 90% of Filipino teenagers use platforms daily, with 20% admitting to sending intimate photos or videos, and 12.5% seeing theirs forwarded without consent. These stats expose how social media warps behavior, normalizing harm under the guise of "just sharing."

The law draws a clear line. Under the Cybercrime Prevention Act of 2012 (Republic Act No. 10175), sharing intimate videos without consent is a serious offense, punishable by fines up to ₱500,000 and imprisonment from six to 12 years—especially if it causes "mental distress" to the victim. Expanded by the Anti-Photo and Video Voyeurism Act (RA 9995) and recent amendments, these rules aim to deter digital vigilantism. Yet enforcement lags the viral pace of content, leaving laws as deterrents rather than shields.

Think of sharing intimate content like planting a poisonous seed in fertile digital soil. One click lets it sprout, spreading uncontrollably through shares and algorithms, poisoning communities far beyond the original poster. You might delete the post, but the damage—screenshots, memories, stigma—lingers forever. Careers crumble, relationships shatter, and reputations scar for life.

In this one-click world, caution must be our compass. We have no right to mock, judge, or amplify someone's mistake, no matter how tempting the outrage. People err—it's human—but every choice, including ours to share, carries weight. Respect demands we pause: Is this share worth ruining a life?

With every impulsive click and share of intimate posts, we don't just harm others; we erode our own values. Let's reclaim respect before one more victim pays the price.

MY ANCHOR

by Psyche Vlaire Y. Bacolod

There was an unspoken tension in the air that day—a quiet storm brewing just beneath the surface. Sharp words flew so suddenly, carrying the weight of disappointment and frustration like an invisible tide crashing within the walls of our home. Yet, amidst the rising waves of emotion, a figure stood silently by my side—a presence calm and unshaken, like the steady rhythm of the sea after the storm. He didn't leave; he stayed. Watching, waiting, ready with a quiet strength that spoke louder than the scolding around me.

My dad is a fisherman, a man whose life is closely intertwined with the ocean's mysteries and moods. His hands—calloused and weathered from years of casting nets and hauling catches under the harsh sun and salty winds—tell countless stories of resilience, patience, and unwavering dedication.

For much of my life, I saw him simply as the man who went to sea every day. But that day, I saw him differently—through my mom's loud voice and his gentle comfort, I finally saw how profoundly special he is.

His advice was simple yet deep, much like the lessons the sea gives us—sometimes harsh, sometimes gentle, always instructive.

He reminded me then that just as the waves rise and fall, our challenges and mistakes recede with time, shaping us into stronger versions of ourselves.

Growing up, I took for granted the quiet sacrifices he made. I overlooked the early mornings he spent preparing his gear, the long hours away from family, and the exhaustion etched in his weary eyes at the end of the day. I never paused to consider the depth of his love, expressed not in grand gestures but in steady, unwavering support.

That afternoon was a revelation—a moment that opened my eyes to the man who has always been my silent cheerleader, though I had failed to notice.

In the days that followed, I found myself reflecting on the countless ways my dad's presence has shaped my world. I recalled the stories he shared from his days at sea—the unpredictable storms, the calm before dawn, the thrill of a good catch—and how those tales carried subtle lessons about resilience and patience.

Fishing is more than just a livelihood for him; it is a metaphor for life's challenges and triumphs, and he has lived those lessons every day.

As I move forward, I carry with me the lessons from that day—the importance of resilience, the strength found in kindness, and the value of seeing those closest to us in their fullest light.

My dad's steady support during my moment of vulnerability was a gift that revealed the depths of his love and the quiet heroism in everyday life.

In honoring him, I honor not just the fisherman who braves the sea but the father who has quietly shaped my story—a man whose strength anchors mine in ways I never fully understood until now.

COURAGE IN THE AFTERMATH

by Lancer Benz Ford P. Pastorite

The sea, usually serene beneath the gaze of the moon, seemed to hold its breath as walls rattled. Houses trembled as if struck by an invisible force. Students who had been resting or reviewing lessons rushed outside, their feet pressing onto the cold streets. It heaved for long, terrifying seconds, and when it finally stopped, the silence felt heavier than the tremor itself.

On September 30, 2025, a magnitude 6.9 earthquake struck Northern Cebu, affecting many places including Santa Fe. Though Kinatarcan did not suffer much destruction, the tremor caused cracks in some buildings that led to class suspensions. Schools checked all the classrooms carefully, and students waited for updates on when it would be safe to return. Education paused—not from broken determination, but because safety came first.

For many students, life after the earthquake became a lesson in uncertainty. There was no rush to wear school uniforms, no sound of classmates chatting before lessons. Instead, students woke up listening vigilantly—not for an alarm, but for any sign of another tremor. People kept glancing nervously at ceilings, mistaking vibrations for aftershocks. Concentration became difficult; the sound of a slamming door could send hearts racing. Education continued—but not without emotional weight.

In time, the shaking stopped—but the silence it left behind felt just as loud as the anger before. Days without classes slowly blended, and students learned that this could be as exhausting as any exam. Yet within that pause, something began to grow. They discovered how to breathe through fear, how to rest with discomfort, and how to wait without giving up.

And so, while school uniforms remained hanging and classrooms stayed empty, the real lesson was already unfolding—that even when life is put on pause, students still have the courage to move forward.

BEYOND THE NUMBERS

by Fern Marie Ilustrisimo

When I first read the headline, “Philippines Logs 138,697 Teen Mothers,” I had to pause. That isn’t just a statistic. It’s 138,697 teenage girls whose lives changed overnight. It’s easy to scroll past numbers on a screen, to treat them as distant data. But behind every digit is a face — a girl my age whose world suddenly flipped upside down.

Official reports say there are nearly 139,000 young mothers across the country. What makes it even more heartbreaking is that many of them are under 15. At fourteen, life is supposed to revolve around school projects, laughter with friends, and simple dreams about the future. Instead, some girls are sitting in clinic waiting rooms, carrying responsibilities far heavier than their peers, stepping into roles they never had the chance to prepare for.

This isn’t happening somewhere far away. It’s happening here — in our own neighborhoods, in places like Calabarzon, Manila and even in Kinatarkan. These are not strangers from another area.

Photo: Rappler

They are classmates, neighbors, and girls we pass on the street without knowing their stories. Teen pregnancy is not “their” issue alone. It is also ours.

Behind every number is a girl whose life looked nothing like she planned. Some girls leave school quietly. Others endure whispers and judgment wherever they go. Many are forced to grow up too fast, trying to be strong for a child while still feeling like children themselves. This is more than a social concern — it is a young girl wondering how she will afford milk, how she will return to school, or whether her dreams are still within reach.

Awareness alone is not enough. Real change begins with honest conversations — about our bodies, our choices, and our responsibilities. It

requires parents who listen without judgment and teachers who create safe spaces for questions. Because silence does not protect us; it only allows the problem to grow.

To some, 138,697 may be just another number in a report. But to me, it is a chorus of interrupted voices. Reducing the number is important, yes — but even more important is ensuring that every girl has the support and opportunity to still shape her own future. Because beyond the numbers are lives that matter, dreams that is entitled to be heard, and futures that can still be pictured.

LIFE OF A STUDENT ATHLETE

by Jadelyn G. Almonicar

Wakeful. Exhausted. Drained. Hopeless. These were the struggles I carried in silence, unseen by others, but conquered through strength and resilience.

Before the sun rises, while most students are still asleep, a student-athlete is already awake, tying shoelaces, packing books, and preparing for another demanding day. This is the quiet reality behind the medals, applause, and school pride.

Being a student-athlete means living two lives in one body. In the classroom, there are lessons to understand, deadlines to meet, and dreams to chase. On the court or field, there are drills to perfect, sweat to endure, and expectations to fulfill. Balancing both is not easy, but it is a challenge embraced with passion and purpose.

Tik. Tak. Tik. Tak. The clock moves relentlessly, each second echoing the weight of my responsibilities. I often find myself asking, “When will this end?” Doubt creeps in, and overthinking takes over, questioning whether I can still manage everything placed before me. “What about my academics?” “What about my training?” “What about myself?”

There are days when exhaustion silences my motivation, when the pressure feels heavier than any physical pain. My body is tired, my mind is restless, and my heart feels overwhelmed. The thought of giving up whispers quietly, tempting me with rest and escape.

Wakeful. While the world sleeps peacefully, I remain wide awake. The clock ticks past midnight, yet my responsibilities are far from over. Activities need to be completed. Deadlines wait for no one. I close my eyes for only a few hours, knowing that before the sun even rises, I must be on my feet again, training, preparing, pushing myself to keep going.

Exhausted. The fatigue does not come from just one place. It comes from schoolwork that demands focus, from household chores that require responsibility, and from training sessions that test both body and spirit. Behind every performance, behind every achievement, there are unseen efforts and sacrifices that often go unnoticed.

Drained. There are moments when my mind simply stops.

I stare into space, thoughts tangled and heavy. The passion is still there, but so is the weight of expectation. The constant cycle of doing, complying, and performing slowly consumes my energy. Mental exhaustion is harder to show, yet it lingers the longest.

Hopeless. Sometimes I find myself wondering why I am here, especially when it feels like I am not getting any closer to achieving my dreams. I feel hopeless about what might happen and uncertain about what the future holds.

But I remind myself that I am more than my fatigue. As a student-athlete, I am shaped by discipline, sacrifice, and resilience. Giving up may seem like an option in moments of weakness, but it is never the choice I take. Each tick of the clock becomes a reminder that persistence is stronger than doubt, and commitment is stronger than fear.

Tik. Tak. Tik. Tak. Time does not pause, but neither do I. I continue to move forward, balancing dreams with responsibilities, proving that strength is not only found in winning, but in enduring.

However, I carry lessons that medals cannot measure discipline, time management, perseverance, and humility. Practice shapes my body, academics shape my future, and together they shape my character. Because beyond medals, my greatest achievement is not what I wear around my neck, but who I am becoming.

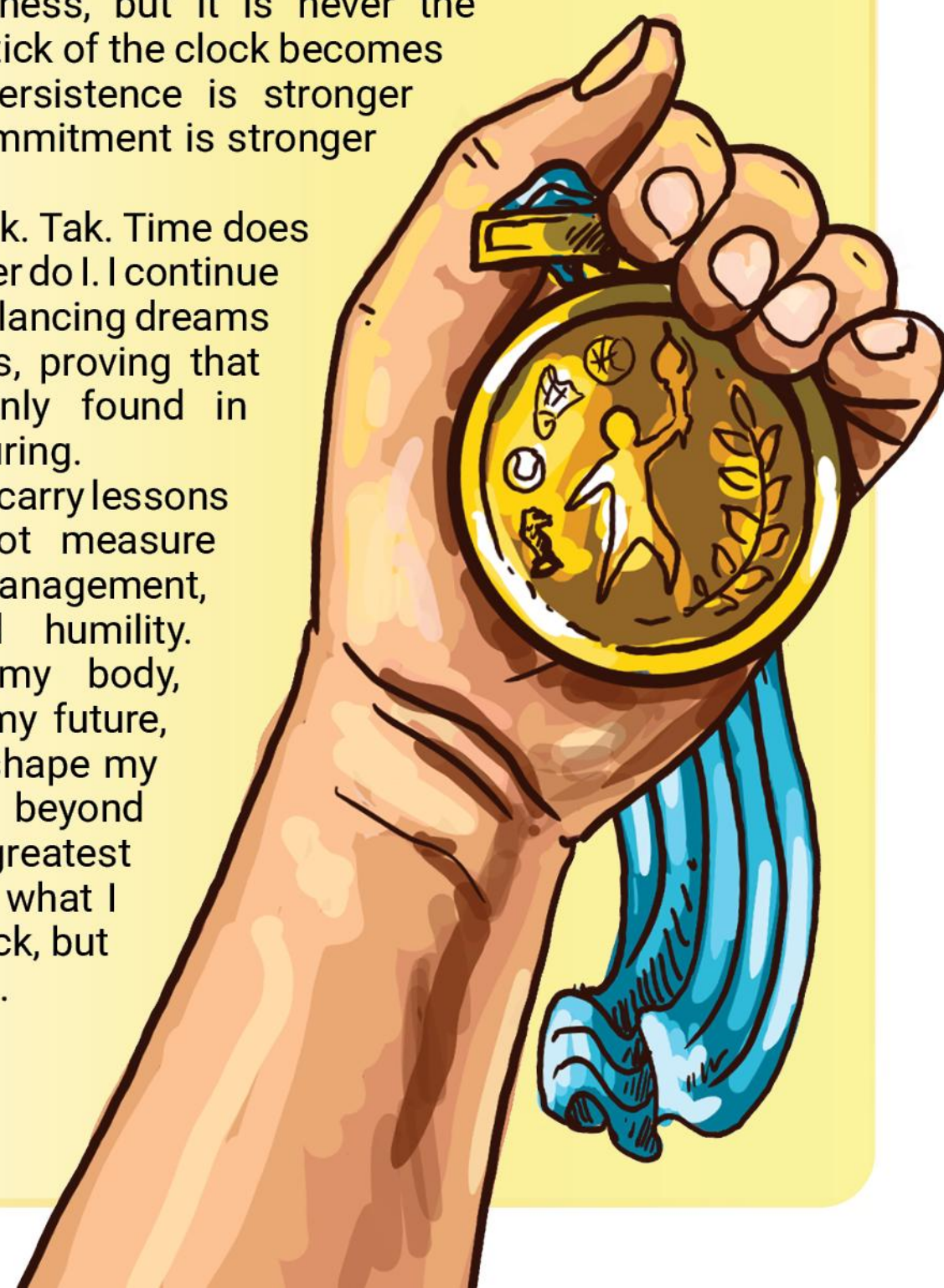




Photo: Philippine Information Agency

SILENT DANGER

The Invisible Threat of Leptospirosis

by Alexa Mae Carabio

When the rain stops and the skies clear, relief usually follows. Streets begin to dry. Families return to their homes. Life starts to feel normal again. But for some, the real danger has only just begun.

In the weeks after major floods in countries like Philippines and Brazil, hospitals often see a quiet surge of patients with high fevers, pounding headaches, and severe muscle pain. At first glance, it looks like the flu or dengue or exhaustion from the disaster. Sometimes, it is something far less recognized called leptospirosis.

According to the Research Institute for Tropical Medicine, Leptospirosis is a zoonotic disease caused by *Leptospira* bacteria and is a major global health threat, particularly in tropical and subtropical regions. It can get in the urine of infected animals such as rats, livestock, and dogs.

For people wading through floodwaters to salvage belongings, clean debris, or simply get home, exposure can happen without them ever realizing it. In warm, wet conditions, the bacteria can survive in soil and water for weeks. The bacteria enter through small cuts in the skin, or even through the eyes, nose, or mouth.

It is not visible, there is no obvious bite, no warning sign. But can destroy you slowly, and that is where fever began to start.

The Department of Health (DOH) reported 5,430 cases of leptospirosis nationwide from June 8 to September 18, 2025, during the peak of the rainy season and floods. Earlier in the season, from June 8 to August 7, there were 2,396 cases recorded nationwide. By early September 2025, another report showed cases had risen to around 4,859 since the start of the rainy season.

In addition, the disease can frighteningly seriously know in its most dangerous form as Weil's disease, it can lead to liver damage, kidney failure, internal bleeding, and inflammation of the brain. In tropical regions, leptospirosis shares symptoms with dengue, malaria, and other infections. Early prescription on doctor can help people to recover with proper antibiotics if treated equally.

Scientists increasingly describe leptospirosis as a disease shaped by environment and infrastructure. Heavier rainfall linked to climate change creates more flooding events that can trigger the disease on surroundings such as floodwaters, contaminated water, drainage, or septic tank.

Moreover, leptospirosis is often called a neglected tropical disease because it disproportionately affects low-income communities and receives less attention than high-profile outbreaks. Yet researchers estimate it causes around one million severe cases globally each year. It thrives the interconnection between the climate change, poverty, and public health gaps.

Diagnosing leptospirosis required waiting for the body to produce detectable antibodies. However, that process can take days. Today, molecular tests such as PCR can detect the bacteria's DNA earlier, giving patients a better chance at prompt treatment.

Veterinary vaccines for dogs and livestock help reduce transmission, and researchers continue to study broader vaccine options. Public health measures rodent control, improved sanitation, protective clothing for high-risk workers, and public awareness campaigns that remain effective tools.

In conclusion, leptospirosis rarely dominates international news cycles. It does not spread explosively or transmit just like a pandemic virus. It does not generate the same global alarm.

Instead, it appears quietly, attacking you slowly the dangers that brings you behind the silence. As extreme weather even grows more frequent and urban populations expand, the conditions that favor leptospirosis are becoming more common.

The lesson from scientists and public health experts is clear: preparation must extend beyond the storm itself. When floodwaters rise, prevention efforts must rise with them.

Because sometimes, the most serious threats are the ones we cannot see and the most dangerous are the ones who keep in silence.

Can Robots Replace Human Jobs?

by Keith Praise Montolo

Technology evolves rapidly, reshaping daily life and work. Just a few decades ago, people relied on keypad phones mainly for texting and calling. Today, smartphones connect to the internet, enable video calls, run apps for navigation, banking, and entertainment—all in one device. This shift highlights how quickly innovation advances, often outpacing individuals' ability to adapt.

As automation accelerates, robots and AI now handle tasks once done exclusively by humans. In factories, they excel at repetitive, heavy, or precision work, operating faster without fatigue or breaks. Companies favor them for boosting efficiency and cutting costs. For instance, Japan leads globally: stores like Henn-na Hotel and certain convenience chains use automated checkouts, robotic greeters, and even humanoid staff to manage operations 24/7.

Recent data underscores this trend. The International Federation of Robotics (IFR) reported in July 2025 (covering 2024) that Japan's automotive sector installed about 13,000 new industrial robots—up from the prior year and the largest increase in years. This surge supports shifts toward electric vehicles (EVs), hydrogen fuel cells, and advanced manufacturing like 3D printing. Japan boasts one of the highest robot densities worldwide, with 419 robots per 10,000 manufacturing workers in 2024, far exceeding the global average of 151 (IFR data).

Yet robots don't always fully replace humans. Automation often fills labor gaps, especially amid aging populations and shortages. In Japan, where over 29% of the population is 65+ (2024 stats), robots handle grunt



Photo: vulcanpost

work, freeing humans for oversight, maintenance, programming, or creative roles. A 2023 Oxford University study estimated that while 47% of U.S. jobs face high automation risk (e.g., assembly lines, data entry), new opportunities emerge in tech fields like AI ethics, robot repair, and data analysis—potentially creating 97 million new jobs by 2025, per the World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2023 update.

Still, concerns linger. Rapid job displacement could widen inequality, particularly for low-skilled workers. The same WEF report predicts 85 million jobs may vanish by 2025 due to automation, hitting sectors like retail and manufacturing hardest. Reskilling programs, universal basic income pilots (e.g., in Finland and Kenya), and policies promoting human-robot collaboration are gaining traction to mitigate this.

Ultimately, technology's promise hinges on responsible use. By investing in education, ethical AI guidelines, and inclusive policies, societies can harness robots to enhance—not erode—human potential, ensuring progress benefits everyone.

The Escalating Challenge of Climate Change and Nature

by Mel Kris Jell B. Gila

Imagine a scorching sun beating down on a clear day, its heat heavier than last year's—heralding a brutal summer. By a riverbank, fishermen mend their nets, anxious about rising temperatures. In distant mountains, farmers gaze at parched rice fields, whispering prayers for rain that may never come. These scenes aren't fiction; they're previews of a world amplified by climate change, where wildfires rage fiercer and more frequently, threatening lives, ecosystems, and our future.

Global warming refers to the long-term rise in Earth's average surface temperature, driven primarily by human activities. Greenhouse gases like carbon dioxide (CO₂) and methane trap heat in the atmosphere, originating from vehicle emissions, industrial factories, fossil fuel combustion, and deforestation. Since the Industrial Revolution, global temperatures have climbed about 1.1°C (2°F), with the last decade (2014–2023) the hottest on record.

This warming supercharges wildfires. Hotter, drier conditions—exacerbated by prolonged droughts and heatwaves—turn forests and grasslands into tinderboxes. For instance, bark beetles, thriving in milder winters, kill drought-stressed trees, leaving vast dead fuel loads. A single spark from lightning or human carelessness can ignite blazes that spread rapidly. In 2023 alone, wildfires scorched over 18 million acres in Canada and the U.S., releasing CO₂ equivalent to India's annual emissions and worsening the warming feedback loop.

Wildfires don't burn in isolation; they're symptoms of disrupted climate patterns. Melting glaciers and polar ice have raised sea levels by about 20–23 cm (8–9 inches) since 1900, at a current rate of roughly 3.7 mm (0.15 inches) per year—not the overstated 0.12 inches annually. This contributes to coastal flooding, while erratic weather brings heatwaves, droughts, and deluges elsewhere.

Nature suffers profoundly. Animals lose habitats; species like koalas in Australia face extinction risks from repeated burns. Crops fail amid water shortages, and invasive insects—emboldened by warmth—spread diseases like dengue and malaria via mosquitoes into new regions. Humans bear the brunt too: smoke from megafires causes respiratory illnesses, with 2020's U.S. West Coast fires linked to thousands of premature deaths. We've hit temperatures unseen in 12,000 years, per ice core data, amplifying these threats.

But it is never too late to take a step and try to reduce the effects of global warming. The first and most important thing is to plant more trees. Due to large-scale deforestation driven by population growth and increasing demand, trees are disappearing rapidly.

A mature tree can absorb about one tonne of carbon dioxide over its lifetime. Through photosynthesis, trees take in carbon dioxide from the air via their leaves. The exact amount depends on the tree species, climate, soil quality, and lifespan.

Second, save energy and switch to renewable sources. This helps protect the planet, improves health, supports the economy, and ensures a cleaner future for everyone.

Finally, launch an awareness campaign in your community. People need to understand the climate change happening around us. A 1.5°C rise might seem small, but in the long run, future generations will face its severe consequences.

Global frameworks like the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) and Paris Agreement guide these efforts. As Gandhi inspired, "Be the change you wish to see in the world." We're late, but planting trees today ensures future generations inherit a resilient planet—not ashes.



Photo: Treehugger

Tombol Reefs Survived in Coral Bleaching

by Joh Lovi Anne D. Osayan

Imagine a colorful underwater world turning white and dying. That's what happened to Tombol Reef in Lian, Batangas, in 2016. Increasing sea temperatures caused severe coral bleaching. Coral reefs lost their symbiotic algae affecting coral tissues, leading to color loss and nutrients deprivation of a coral. Fish and sea creatures had no home and starved to death. But marine scientists from De La Salle University (DLSU) and volunteer divers from Reef Check Philippines helped it recover. It's now full of life.

The revival of coral reefs by banning destructive fishing methods, regular reef monitoring during summer, coral transplantation from more resilient area, and community education on marine conservative these are simple steps to make our corals healthy and grow more. Live coral cover increased from 20% in 2017 to 55% in 2024. With the reappearance of parrotfish, butterflyfish, and other indicator species.

Why is Coral reefs important?

They give food and livelihood for local fishermen, block strong waves and storms, and help tourism and the diving industry. The coral reef serves as habitat for various species of fish, mollusks, and crustaceans. Its recovery shows reefs can heal with proper protection and care.

Experts and local are excited, based on Dr. Theresa Mundita Lim, a marine biologist, "Tombol Reef is proof that even after severe damage, our coral reefs can bounce back if given enough time and protection. However, climate change remains a constant threat, and government, scientists, and local communities must work hand in hand to sustain this recovery."

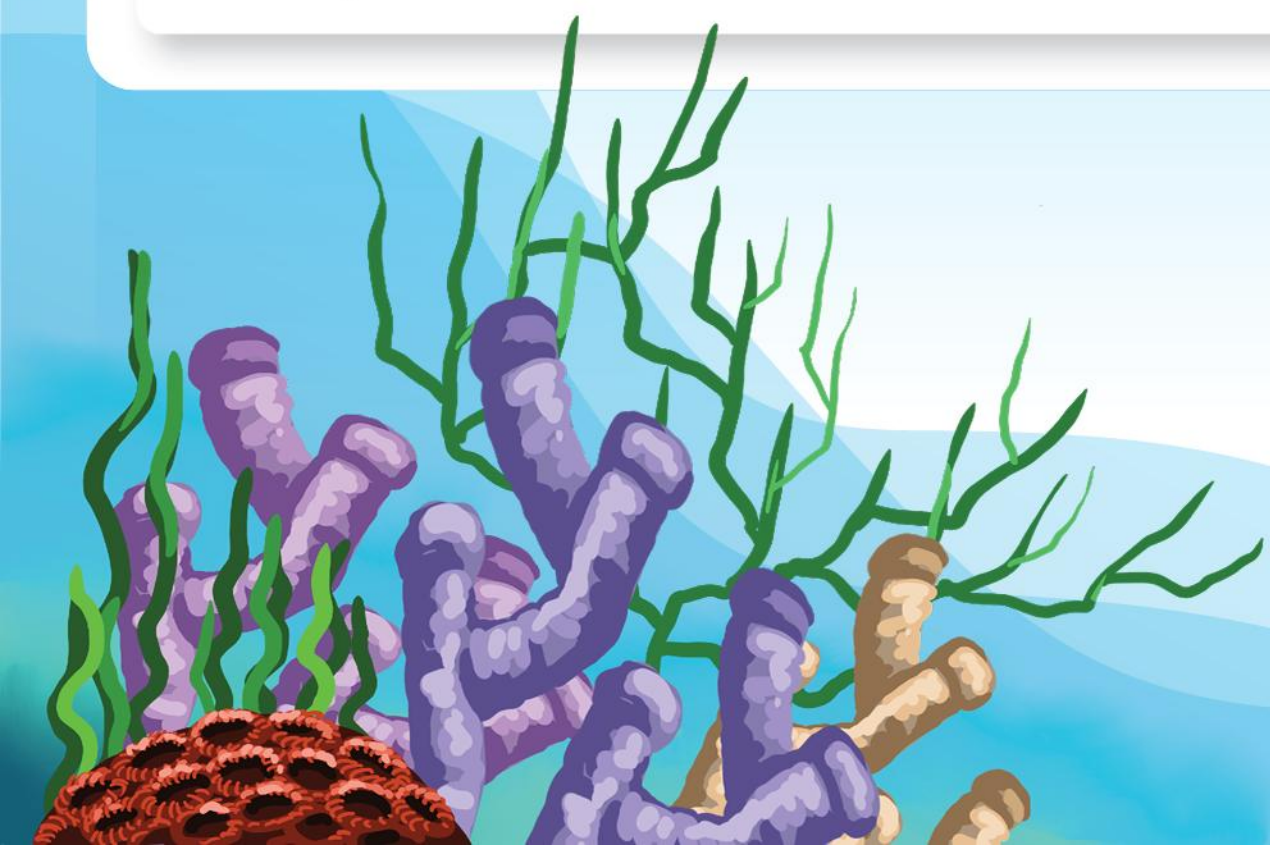
Antonio de la Cruz, 52, a local fisherman from Lian shared his joy, "Before, we barely caught enough fish for the day, but now the waters are coming back to life. I can see more fish near the shore, and my children will hopefully inherit a healthy sea."

From the helpers: "The Tombol Reef story is not just about science, but also about community partnership. People are realizing that protecting the sea means protecting their own future," says Liza Bautista, coordinator, Reef Check Philippines.

The comeback of marine life inspires us. It gives us hope that we must act immediately.

Pollution must be reduced, coastal development regulated, and marine protected areas continuously supported to keep it safe from future degradation.

Let's all safeguard our seas together!



UNSTOPPABLE DOMINANCE

KNHS athletes secure CVIRAA berth

by **Berlito G. Mantao Jr.**

In every stride and in every match, the athletes of Kinatarcan National High School carried with them courage, discipline, and the determination to bring honor to their school. And that was exactly what they did as they claimed five golds, four silvers, and four bronze medals in Provincial Meet 2026, at Naga City, Cebu on February 15-20 — and book them a CVIRAA ticket.

Under the blazing heat of the unforgiving sun, while others search for shade, Heart Y. Monterde captured two gold medals in the 300-meter and 1,500-meter runs and added a silver medal in the 800-meter event, showcasing her endurance and determination on the track.

Meanwhile, Kerstene Marie V. Bacolod dominated the 400-meter and 200-meter runs, claiming gold medals in both events and proving her speed and skill on the track.

Not to be outdone, the more experienced and only male athlete, Kian I. Oftana, also made his mark by bringing home a silver medal in the 800-meter run and two bronze medals in the 300-meter run and 1,500-meter run events.

The seasoned talent of Mariel Collarin lit up the track as she seized gold medals in both the 800-meter and 1,500-meter runs, proving her dominance and brilliance in the competition.

On the other hand, Prinsesa Hyra Zaspas also showcased her strength and skill in the shot put and discus throw. She added to the school's medal haul by claiming a silver medal in the shot put and a bronze medal in the discus throw.

Also, the smallest but an agile athlete, Arian Alilin, showed her brilliance by claiming a silver medal in the 1500-meter run and a bronze in the 3,000-meter run.

Moreover, Mariel Collarin, Heart Monterde, Shara Joy Placencia, and Kerstene Marie Bacolod, showed their dominance in the track as they bag a gold medal in 4x400-meter run.



In a sought interview with Ang Serilya, the proud athletes revealed their inspiration in winning. At the same time, their coach Mr. Juniel Tahanlangit also expressed his feelings about their achievements.

"Inspirasyon nakon ang akong pamilya ug ang akong skwelahan nga andam nga mutabang ug musuporta sa akon," Monterde indicated.

"Inspirasyon nakon ang akong pamilya nga ara pirme mutabang, skwelahan nga andam mo suporta, ug labaw sa tanan sir Ronilo nga andam mo tudlo sa amon," Bacolod stated.

"Ang akon inspirasyon kay ang akong papa, kay kahibawo ko nga ara da sya andam mo suporta ug mutabang sa akon, ug kahibawo lat ko sa akong kaugalingon nga kaya ug may abilidad ko sina," Oftana mentioned.

"I feel proud of the achievement of my athletes, since they already reaped the reward from their hardwork during their rigorous training", said Sir Tahanlangit.

"Focus lang gyud kami sa training ug amon e improve ang dapat namon e improve, para more chances of winning sa CVIRAA," he added.

Together, these athletes proved that talent, hard work, and determination know no limits. Under the blazing sun and against every challenge, they showed their brilliance, turned sweat into triumph, and carried their school's honor across every finish line and field.

Their victories are not just medals — they are a testament to the power of courage, teamwork, and dreams pursued without fear.

As of now, the athletes are now busy training for the Central Visayas Regional Athletic Association (CVIRAA) on March 22-28, to be hosted by Naga City.

CROWN REGAINED

KNHS snaps back overall championship in Municipal Meet 2025



by **Joh Lovi Anne D. Osayan, Precious Venus Buan**

Kinatarcan National High School emerged as the overall champion with 26 gold, 24 silver, and 11 bronze medals in the recently concluded Municipal Sports Meet and Cultural Festival held on December 12-14 in Santa Fe, Cebu, with the theme "Fueling Minds, Championing Skills through Sports and Cultural Competition."

On the first day of the three-day event, KNHS kicked off strong in badminton and athletics, with Lyka Mae Brian and Queen Hara Zaspas winning gold in the women's singles A and B categories. In the throwing events, Princess Hyra Zaspas shone brightest, grabbing gold in shot put and discus throw, plus silver in javelin.

Day two grew even more intense with the cultural events. Larah Mae Escalicas defended her Balak gold, the Balitaw team took first place, and the Dance Sports squads swept gold in both Latin American and Modern Standard. The chess teams dominated the Blitz events (gold for both male and female categories), while Regilyn Mancio won Scrabble gold. In the King and Queen of the Cultural Festival search, Kert Desierto earned second runner-up; Princess Niña Gerra swept Best in Production Number, Best in Ramp Walk, and Best in Make-up (female category); and Veronica Batianila took the Best Make-up Artist award.

Athletics capped the event with multiple golds, including wins from Hannah May Oftana (100m and 200m girls), Heart Monterde (1500m and 3000m girls), Kian Ilustrisimo (1500m and 3000m boys), and Mariel Collarin (girls' long jump and triple jump.)

Mrs. Katherine R. Escalicas, School Head of KNHS, expressed her pride and gratitude for the efforts and performances of the students and coaches.

"I feel fulfilled and happy, of course, for the results nga naachieve naton aton goals. Normal da gyud na nga aray pildi kay dili man ta perfect, aton mga athletes di lat perfect. Dawaton naton kung nano ang results unya happy gyapon ta," she stated.

KNHS's resounding victory not only fuels young minds and hones champion skills but also sets the stage for provincial glory—proving once again that with heart, hustle, and determination, Kinatarcan's athletes are unstoppable.

HISTORY MAKER

Brando Sisdoyro shines in swimming tilt

by **Mark Jhon Derder**

Amid the intense competition, Kinatarcan National High School's ace swimmer Brando L. Sisdoyro didn't fall behind and clinched the team's first-ever silver medal in the 200-meter breaststroke event during the Provincial Sports and Cultural Meet held on February 14-20 at the Carcar City Olympic Swimming Pool.

In addition, he showcased his skills in the 100-meter breaststroke, securing a bronze medal, while placing fifth in the 50-meter breaststroke.

Greg Lorence D. Derodar also shone brightly, earning fifth place in the 100-meter freestyle, seventh in the 50-meter backstroke, ninth in both the 100-meter backstroke and 200-meter freestyle, and 11th in the 50-meter butterfly.

Similarly, John Wilnar B. Calanes grabbed fifth place in the 100-meter breaststroke, 14th in the 50-meter butterfly, and 17th in the 50-meter freestyle.

Meanwhile, John Laurice B. Canales brought home 11th place in the 100-meter freestyle and 15th in the 50-meter freestyle.

Bernie A. Alolod rounded out the individual efforts with 14th place in the 50-meter breaststroke.

Finally, the team of Greg Lorence D. Derodar, Brando L. Sisdoyro, John Wilnar B. Canales, and John Laurice B. Canales secured fourth place in both the 4x50 medley relay and the 4x50 freestyle relay.

Under the guidance of their coach, Mrs. Rhea P. Pastorite, and trainer Mr. Irwin R. Ilustrisimo, the swimmers' hard work paid off—despite limited practice time.



KNHS DLC claims 10th straight Band Palabas victory

by **Precious Venus Buan**

The Drum and Lyre Corps (DLC) of Kinatarcan National High School delivered an outstanding performance as they showcased their talents in drumming and dancing in Band Palabas, held last January 16 at Santa Fe Cultural and Sports Complex.

As KNHS DLC entered the complex, they were welcomed with a round of applause, powerful cheers, and overwhelming support from KNHS teachers and parents.

From start to finish, KNHS DLC gave a powerful rhythm, breathtaking choreography, and a truly remarkable performance that will forever hold a special place in everyone's heart.

